

So You're Thinking About Grad School

A Practical Guide to

:not-fully-understanding-the-value-of-a-bachelor's-degree

Upon the brink of graduation's gate, Your peers suggest you carry on to school, The path of further education's weight, Deserves your careful thought, not someone else's rule.

So sit and listen while I make the case, That you probably don't need another degree, Your bachelor's got you a perfectly fine face, Now go make some money, seriously, go be free.

Why This Talk Exists (You're Welcome For This Life Advice)

- ▶ You're graduating in a few months
- ▶ Someone said "you should go to grad school"
- ▶ You want to know if that's actually good advice

Agenda: Learn enough to make your own decision

Poll Time (Approximately How Many of You Are Here Against Your Will)

Who here has been told “you should go to grad school”?

(Raise your hand or just think about it)

The Two Types of Grad Programs (Choose Your Own Misadventure)

Hear now the tale of two academic roads, The *Master's* path where coursework *reigns* supreme, Where *students* pay their tuition's heavy loads, And *finely* earn a more specialized dream.

The *Doctor's* way is different in form, A five to seven year expedition deep, Where *scholars* search through knowledge's permanent storm, And *faculties* forge their scholarly keep.

The former costs you precious golden cash, The latter pays you stipends low but true, One leads to work and money with a flash, The other to research, whatever you do.

Choose wisely now, dear student, choose your fate, The world of words awaits at worthy's gate.

Master's Degree Pathways (Deep Thoughts With Interest Rates)

1. Same Major

- ▶ CS → MS CS
- ▶ IT → MS IT
- ▶ Robotics → MS Robotics

Why: More depth in what you already know

Master's: Related Fields (Pivot Harder: The Sequel)

2. Pivot to Adjacent Tech

- ▶ CS → Data Science / AI-ML
- ▶ CS → Cybersecurity
- ▶ IT → Software Engineering
- ▶ Any → Computer Engineering

Why: Specialization = higher pay, more job security

Master's: Different Field (The Career Reset Button Press Carefully)

3. Complete Change

- ▶ CS → MBA (tech management track)
- ▶ CS → Healthcare Informatics
- ▶ CS → Law (IP / tech law)
- ▶ Any → Teaching (MAT)

Why: Broaden your career options

Dual Degrees (Twice the Tuition Half the Sleep)

The Power Move

- ▶ MBA + MS CS (University of Delaware, UNLV)
- ▶ MS CS + Robotics
- ▶ MS CS + Computational Biology

Why: Business + Technical = Chief Technology Officer

PhD: What's the Point?

Five full fortunes spent in faculties forsaken, Slogging through scholarship for science's sake, Struggling with structures, with theorems, with theory, Burdened with burning questions that beat and that break.

For those who persevere, a fortune may wait, In god-e-given gloubular giants of code, Where researchers resonate, where reward is great, But woe to the wanderer who wanders the road.

For the master who maketh the commit to know, The cost is a career of computation, A decade of doom in the digging below, A destination of doctorate frustration.

Yet if your heart be hardened to higher desire, To scrawl with the scholars, to scrutinize truth, Then persevere, persevere, let noone despire, For knowledge is noble, though noble in sooth.

PhD by the Numbers (The Spreadsheet of Sadness)

Sector	Entry Salary	Mid-Career
Big Tech (FAANG)	\$180K-\$220K	\$300K-\$500K+
Traditional Tech	\$120K-\$160K	\$200K-\$300K
Finance	\$130K-\$180K	\$250K-\$400K
Academia	\$70K-\$120K	\$100K-\$180K

Source: ValidGrad, BLS 2024-2025

Why Consider Grad School? (Let's Pretend This Is Mandatory)

1. Higher Starting Salary

- ▶ **Bachelor's CS:** ~\$76K average (2025)
- ▶ **Master's CS:** ~\$94K average (Class of 2026)
- ▶ **PhD (industry):** \$180K+ starting

That's a meaningful difference

Why Consider Grad School? (Follow the Money)

2. Access to Specializations

Roles that basically require grad school:

- ▶ Machine Learning Engineer
- ▶ Computer Vision Researcher
- ▶ Robotics Engineer (some positions)
- ▶ Research Scientist

You *can* get these with a BS, but it takes years of self-study

Why Consider Grad School?

3. Career Pivoting

“I want to do AI but my BS was in IT”

A master's is the cleanest way to switch tracks

Reality: Many employers screen by degree

Why Consider Grad School? (Just Pivot: The Documentary)

4. Job Security and Advancement

- ▶ More degrees = more senior positions
- ▶ Management tracks often prefer advanced degrees
- ▶ Layoffs hit junior devs harder

Why Consider Grad School? (They Can't Fire Me If I'm Still In School)

5. Faculty / Research Career

If you want to be a professor

- ▶ PhD is required (non-negotiable)
- ▶ Plan for 5-7 years of low pay
- ▶ Published research is currency

Honest take: Academic job market is brutal

Why NOT Grad School? (The Price Is Wrong And It's Always Been Wrong)

The *price* is *wrong*, and it's *always* been *wrong*, You *could* be making *money* all day *long*!

Two *years* of tuition will *cost* you a *fortune*, While *classmates* earn *salary*—meanwhile, you're in *forum*.

Sixty thousand for tuition (just a *start*), Plus *eighty thousand* you could be making in *cart*.

Two *hundred grand* *lost* when all's *said* and *done*, You could have bought *cars*—now, isn't that *fun*?

So *think* before you *sign* away your *youth*, The *best* education comes from *real-world truth*.

Why NOT Grad School? (You Could Be Making Money RIGHT NOW)

2. Industry Experience Wins

Fact: A dev with 5 years of experience > fresh MS grad

- ▶ You learn things in industry you can't in school
- ▶ Companies value proven production code
- ▶ Senior devs with BS out-earn fresh MS

Why NOT Grad School? (XP Matters More Than Your GPA)

3. Many Tech Jobs Don't Need It

Roles that are totally accessible with BS

- ▶ Frontend Developer
- ▶ Backend Developer
- ▶ Full-Stack Engineer
- ▶ DevOps / SRE
- ▶ Most “Software Engineer” roles at big companies

Why NOT Grad School? (Bachelor's Degree Still Valid Barely)

4. The “I’ll figure out what to do in grad school” Trap

Bad reason to go

- ▶ “I don’t know what else to do”
- ▶ “My parents want me to”
- ▶ “It seems like the next step”

This is a \$100K+ mistake

Why NOT Grad School? (The I'll Figure It Out Pipeline)

5. You Can Always Go Back

Part-time options exist

- ▶ Online programs (Georgia Tech OMSCS: \$7K total)
- ▶ Executive MBAs
- ▶ Company-sponsored degrees

No penalty for waiting

Why NOT Grad School? (It's Called Burnout Because That's What You'll Be)

6. Academic Burnout is Real

Grad school is

- ▶ 5-7 years of poverty (\$30-50K/year)
- ▶ Uncertainty about advisor fit
- ▶ Publication pressure
- ▶ Imposter syndrome

Ask yourself: Do you *need* this, or do you just think you do?

The Real Talk: When Grad School Makes Sense (In Certain Extreme Circumstances)

1. You want a very specific, specialized role

- ▶ ML Engineer at top labs
- ▶ Research Scientist
- ▶ Faculty position
- ▶ Highly specialized robotics

2. Career pivot from non-CS field

- ▶ Biology → Computational Biology
- ▶ Liberal Arts → Data Science (with bridge program)

3. Company requires it

- ▶ Some research positions
- ▶ Government clearances

The Real Talk: When to Skip It (How to Win Friends and Save Money)

1. You just want “more education”

That's what books are for. Free ones.

2. You think it guarantees a job

It doesn't. Experience > degree, usually.

3. You're avoiding the job market

The job market will still be there in 2 years

Practical Realities: Applications (Apply Directly to the Forehead)

What you need

- ▶ **GPA:** Usually 3.0 minimum (3.5+ competitive)
- ▶ **Statement of Purpose:** Why this program? Why now?
- ▶ **Letters of Recommendation:** Need 2-3, from people who know your work
- ▶ **GRE:** Many schools dropped this (check!)

Practical Realities: Funding (May the Curves Be Ever in Your Favor)

Master's

Tuition piles high Stipends barely feed the soul— Debt or death?
Choose.

PhD

Funded, yes, they pay Thirty thousand per long year— Freedom?
Just barely.

Negotiation possible. Ask and ye shall receive.

Practical Realities: Timeline (The Only Thing We Have to Fear Is Fear Itself)

If you want to start Fall 2026

- ▶ **Now - Jan 2026:** Research programs, visit campuses
- ▶ **January - March 2026:** Ask for letters, write statements
- ▶ **March - April 2026:** Applications due
- ▶ **April - May 2026:** Decisions arrive
- ▶ **May - August 2026:** Relax, maybe work

Making Your Decision (Decisions Were Made)

Questions to ask yourself

1. What job do I want? Does it *require* grad school?
2. Can I get there another way?
3. Am I passionate about this topic?
4. Can I afford it (financially and mentally)?
5. What will I regret not doing?

The “Work First” Argument (The Paid Internship of Life But Forever)

When *fresh* from college with your *degrees* in *hand*, And everyone says “*go to grad school now!*”, Just *pause* and *think* of *what* you’ve *already planned*, And *how* much *money* you could *make* somehow.

Your *bachelor’s* is *worth* its *weight* in *gold*, Not *just* a *stepping* stone to *more* debt, Go *work* and *learn* what *truly* can be *sold*, Before you’re *burdened* with a *loan* you’ll *get*.

For *three* short *years* of *work* will *teach* you *more*, Than *two* years *holed* up in a *library*, You’ll *know* just *what* you *want* to *explore*, And *have* the *cash* to *pay* for *misery*.

So *work* first, *earn*, and *then* decide your *course*, Don’t *rush* to *school*—you’ll *regret* it, of *course*!

Summary (TL;DR: Good Luck)

A student who rushed to grad school fast, Found their debt would forever last. They could have worked instead, Made money, learned ahead— Now they wish that choice had never been cast!

The actual summary

- ▶ **Grad school is:** A tool, not a requirement
- ▶ **Worth it for:** Specific goals
- ▶ **Not worth it for:** “More education”

The best advice

- ▶ Get a job first
- ▶ Figure out what you actually want
- ▶ Then decide if grad school helps

Resources (Further Reading for People Who Clicked Away From TikTok)

Where to learn more

- ▶ US News & World Report (rankings)
- ▶ CS Career Questions (Reddit)
- ▶ The Professor Is In (academic careers)
- ▶ Program websites (for specific info)

Questions? (Q&A: Or Why I'm Here Until the Fire Alarm)

Thank You